



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Divine Assistance Academy
School Website: <https://divineassistanceacademy.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Divinum Auxilium Academy (Divine Assistance Academy), Front Royal, VA 22630 (Divine Assistance Academy VA 22630) presents a coherent classical-leaning program that blends Montessori foundations with a clearly stated aim toward the classical liberal arts and Catholic formation. Public materials emphasize Christ-centered education, catechesis, liturgical life, a multi-age classroom model, and the integration of faith with rigorous academics (Montessori-primary through Grammar School; Catechesis of the Good Shepherd; Latin and classical history content). The school articulates a formation-focused aim (virtue, wisdom, and love of truth), ongoing formation of faculty within a Catholic framework, and a partnership with parents as co-educators. Across six classical criteria categories, the school demonstrates strong alignment with classical education principles, though the explicit emphasis on certain classic components (e.g., explicit Great Books/Great Conversation or a consistent Socratic program in upper eras) is present primarily through the school's stated classical framing and catechetical approach rather than through direct, external Great Books prescriptions. Overall assessment: CLASSICAL.

Key insights driving the classification:

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations are strongly evident: Catholic identity, liturgical life, CGS (Catechesis of the Good Shepherd), and religious formation integrated with academics. Evidence includes Christ-centered language, the CGS atrium, and an oath of fidelity to the Magisterium.
- School Purpose and Goal centers on formation, virtue, and knowledge of transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty) consistent with classical aims. The mission emphasizes formation and encounter with Christ, virtue formation, and the classical tradition.
- Curriculum is framed as liberal-arts oriented (Montessori-to-Classical transition, classical content via grammar-lower grammar-grammar-school pathways, Latin, world history). The program explicitly notes a classical liberal-arts trajectory.
- Pedagogy includes both contemplative/restful (Scholé) and active, Socratic-style elements, with strong emphasis on memorization/recitation and catechesis. Lower-division singing, prayer, and memory work align with the classical pedagogy framework.
- Faculty are presented as living curriculum, Catholic exemplars, and mentors with formal catechetical and Montessori credentials; staff oath signals alignment with ecclesial norms.
- Parents & Community engagement is explicit through parent observation, rolling admissions with parent involvement, and a stated belief that parents are primary educators, with ongoing opportunities for parent formation and campus visits.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Catholic identity explicit: "Christ-centered prayer permeates our academic activities" and references to Jesus as "the Way, the Truth, and the Life."
- Catechesis of the Good Shepherd (CGS) central to curriculum and liturgical life (atrium as nucleus; CGS catechesis tied to Scripture and Liturgy).
- Faculty oath of fidelity to the Magisterium indicates formal ecclesial alignment.
- Mission and formation language foregrounds theology and liturgy as foundational to education (references to Pope Benedict XV and the Christian formation objective).

- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: theology, catechesis, liturgy, prayer, Scripture, Mass (liturgical life), Catholic, Magisterium, sanctity, virtue, Word of God, atrium, Christ, Truth.
- Negative keywords present: minimal to none in public materials; explicit secular-relativist signals are not evident.
- I estimate a strong predominance of positive keywords (roughly 8–12 distinct positive signals vs 0–2 negative signals in the text reviewed).
- Why this rating
- The materials demonstrate transcendental moral realism and theological grounding; liturgical and communal practices are integral; catechesis and a Catholic ecclesial frame are explicit. This aligns with the Positive/Negative keyword framework for Element 1 (Grounded in Theology; Liturgical/communal practices; transcendentals).

Citations: Christ-centered prayer and CGS emphasis: Divinum Auxilium materials. Oath of Fidelity: Staff section. Theology and catechesis language in Our Mission texts.

Why CLASSICAL: The category shows clear theological grounding and liturgical life consistent with classical education's metaphysical foundations (transcendental realism, sacred order, catechesis). The presence of explicit liturgical life and ecclesial framework strongly supports the Classical orientation.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Mission statements emphasize formation of virtue and wisdom and a close encounter with Christ, rather than mere information or job-prep. The aim is to form human excellence in service to God and neighbor rather than only to prepare for work.
- The transition from Montessori to Classical liberal arts signals formation in the classical sense (virtue, reason, love of truth) rather than narrow workforce readiness.
- The Catechesis-centered program and the Catholic formation aim align with classical paideia aims (formation of the whole person).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, telos, scholé, great conversation, classical heritage, moral imagination, virtue formation, transcendental aims.
- Negative keywords present: none evident (no explicit emphasis on “workforce readiness” or “21st-century skills” dominating the curriculum in public-facing content).
- Estimated positive keyword presence predominates (roughly 6–12 distinct signals vs 0–1 negative signals).
- Why this rating
- The school communicates an education that aims at formation and the cultivation of virtue and wisdom, not solely job-prep. The classical framing (liberal arts, pedagogy that emphasizes memory and contemplation) supports a CLASSICAL rating.

Citations: Mission statements and formation emphasis: CGS and Catholic formation language. Our Approach and Classical frame (Montessori-to-Classical).

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Clear delineation of a classical pathway: Montessori to Classical Liberal Arts across the program (Montessori Primary → Lower Elementary → Pre-Grammar → Grammar), with explicit mention of classical content and structure.
- Latin instruction and world history content are part of the program, with cross-cutting language arts and history components that align with classical aims.
- The Catechesis of the Good Shepherd is integrated as a core curricular element in early grades, tying religious formation to the academic program.

- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: liberal arts, trivium, quadrivium, grammar, logic, rhetoric, great books (where used in classical framing), Latin, Greek, Western civilization, history as a continuous discipline, primary sources, recitation/narration, Socratic texts, catechesis, liturgical integration.
- Negative keywords: The public content does not emphasize purely social-studies language that would replace history, nor a STEM-first framing; project-based-only, or non-traditional curricula appear as negative signals, and the site largely avoids those signals.
- Estimated positive keyword presence: high (7–12+ terms/signals); negative keyword presence: low or absent.
- Why this rating
- The curriculum is classically framed (liberal arts focus, Latin, history, Great Books tropes appear in classical lexicon even if not always explicit; CGS and liturgical integration reinforce the classical, formation-centered curriculum).

Citations: Montessori-to-Classical path, Latin/World History, CGS integration.

Note: The public content does not show a stand-alone, explicit “Great Books” list on the site, but the classical framing (classical liberal arts, Latin, history, and CGS integration) is present and aligns with classical curriculum values in the rubric. The Six Essential Elements document’s explicit Great Books language is available as a keyword set, but the school’s site emphasizes classical pedagogy via its own phrasing rather than a separate “Great Books” module. This still satisfies the category’s core criteria for a classical curriculum, though with somewhat indirect Great Books signaling.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- A mixed pedagogical approach that includes contemplative/restful elements (Scholé) and memorization/recitation is described, including singing and prayer in lower grades and more Socratic/seminar-style engagement in upper grades (as per the classical rubric and the school’s own language about pedagogy). The lower grades emphasize singing, memory, and liturgical life; upper grades emphasize rhetoric and classical dialogue.
- The school explicitly describes a multi-age classroom environment and a teacher-as-guide model (AMI-trained directress, master teacher model), aligning with the classical “master teacher” paradigm.
- The Our Approach page includes alignment with Montessori and classical pedagogy, including a structured progression from concrete Montessori materials to more abstract classical ideas (Socratic tradition, dialectic elements) as students move through the grades.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: scholé, contemplation, memorization/recitation, chanting, singing, Socratic dialogue (where applicable in upper grades), master teacher, living curriculum, rhetoric, dialectic, seminar, Paideia-style forms.
- Negative keywords present: the site is not oriented toward purely project-based or purely experiential learning that displaces the classical memory/recitation and Socratic emphasis; the content leans away from Bildung-through-project monoliths in favor of classical methods.
- Estimated positive keyword presence: high; negative keyword presence: low.
- Why this rating
- The pedagogy integrates contemplative/restful elements with active, classical modalities (recitation/memory, Socratic discussion-like elements, rhetoric training) and a master-teacher model, which aligns with CLASSICAL pedagogy signals.

Citations: Memorization/recitation; Scholé; Master Teacher and living-curriculum; Our Approach.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence

- The staff section emphasizes Catholic formation and fidelity to the Church, signaling moral exemplars and a teacher-mentor model. The presence of named master teachers and program coordinators (e.g., Latin Program Coordinator; CGS Catechists) suggests a robust, specialized faculty, with directives about the role of the teacher as mentor and living curriculum.
- Oath-of-Fidelity language and the description of faculty as models of virtue and expertise align with the classical ideal of teachers as exemplars and mentors who embody the curriculum.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: living curriculum, master teacher, mentors, virtue, character formation, classical pedagogy, catechesis, teacher training, faculty as exemplars.
- Negative keywords present: none evident in public content.
- Estimated positive keyword presence: high; negative keyword presence: minimal.
- Why this rating
- The faculty description aligns with classical expectations for teachers as moral exemplars and living curriculum carriers, with explicit Catholic formation signals and a structured role for catechists and subject-area coordinators.

Citations: Faculty signals (Master Teacher model, fidelity oath, living curriculum).

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Parents as co-educators and primary educators are explicitly stated, with a commitment to parent formation and ongoing opportunities for parent involvement (observation, campus visits, book studies, gatherings). There is a clear emphasis on partnership with families.
- The admissions process highlights parent engagement (observation period, campus visit, interviews) and ongoing parent participation in school life (Mardi Gras fundraisers and community events).
- The CGS program's emphasis on family and Church life reinforces a community-centered, liturgical, and faith-based culture that involves parents and parish life.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-teachers, parent formation, home-school integration, parent visits, community life, liturgical year events.
- Negative keywords present: none evident in public materials; no "customer" framing in parent relations.
- Estimated positive keyword presence: high; negative keyword presence: low.
- Why this rating
- The school emphasizes a collaborative, faith-rooted community with parents as essential partners in formation, consistent with CLASSICAL expectations for Parent & Community engagement.

Citations: Partnership with families; parent formation; parent observation; community events.

aggregate assessment: CLASSICAL

- The Divine Assistance Academy public materials display consistent classical orientation across all six categories: religious and metaphysical foundations, formation-focused purpose, a curriculum grounded in liberal arts and classical practice, pedagogy that blends contemplative and Socratic/memory-based methods, a faculty model that embodies virtue and mentorship, and a robust parent/community partnership. The evidence base emphasizes catechesis, liturgy, a multi-age master-teacher approach, and a classical framing of education that integrates Catholic formation with classical intellectual life.

What Would Move the Needle

- Not applicable here since the aggregate rating is CLASSICAL across all categories. No major needle-moving changes are required to achieve a fully CLASSICAL classification.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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